PROMISE & PRACTICE · GROWTH & CONFLICT · SOURCE ANALYSIS

The Anthem

A war going badly

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

WHAT I CAN DO TODAY I can read primary sources about The Anthem, weigh who made each one and why, and use evidence to answer historical questions.

Directions. Most Americans never learn that “The Star-Spangled Banner” has a third verse, or that it mentions slaves. Should a U.S. history class teach verse three — or is verse one enough? Make your case



Francis Scott Key (1779–1843) — portrait, public domain.

THE SOURCES

YOUR WORK

A. WHO WROTE THE POEM, IN WHAT YEAR, AND WHAT WAS HE DOING ON A BRITISH SHIP WHEN THE BATTLE HAPPENED?

a. Who wrote the poem, in what year, and what was he doing on a British ship when the battle happened?

B. SOURCING QUESTION: KEY WAS A SLAVEHOLDER WATCHING A BATTLE IN A WAR WHERE THE BRITISH WERE FREEING ENSLAVED PEOPLE. BEFORE YOU READ A SINGLE LINE, WHAT SHOULD THAT MAKE YOU READ CAREFULLY FOR?

b. Sourcing question: Key was a slaveholder watching a battle in a war where the British were freeing enslaved people. Before you read a single line, what should that make you read carefully for?

A. THE VERSE ENDS WITH A QUESTION MARK. WHAT EXACTLY IS KEY ASKING — AND WHY DOESN'T HE KNOW THE ANSWER YET? POINT TO THE WORDS THAT SHOW HIS UNCERTAINTY.

a. The verse ends with a question mark. What exactly is Key asking — and why doesn't he know the answer yet? Point to the words that show his uncertainty.

B. "BOMBS BURSTING IN AIR" SOUNDS TRIUMPHANT WHEN WE SING IT. IN ITS REAL MOMENT, WHAT DID THOSE BURSTING BOMBS ACTUALLY MEAN FOR THE PEOPLE INSIDE THE FORT?

b. "Bombs bursting in air" sounds triumphant when we sing it. In its real moment, what did those bursting bombs actually mean for the people inside the fort?

A. THE MELODY WAS A BRITISH DRINKING-CLUB SONG ABOUT WINE AND LOVE. WHAT DOES IT TELL YOU ABOUT HOW NATIONAL SYMBOLS ARE MADE, THAT THE MOST PATRIOTIC AMERICAN SONG BORROWED A BRITISH BAR TUNE?

a. The melody was a British drinking-club song about wine and love. What does it tell you about how national symbols are made, that the most patriotic American song borrowed a British bar tune?

B. RE-READ VERSE 3 (“NO REFUGE COULD SAVE THE HIRELING AND SLAVE…”) AND ITS CONTEXT: THE BRITISH WERE OFFERING FREEDOM TO ENSLAVED PEOPLE WHO ESCAPED. HISTORIANS DISAGREE ABOUT WHAT KEY MEANT. LAY OUT BOTH READINGS — THE ONE THAT SAYS HE’S MOCKING FREEDOM-SEEKERS, AND THE ONE THAT SAYS HE MEANS BRITISH SOLDIERS BROADLY.

b. Re-read verse 3 (“No refuge could save the hireling and slave…”) and its context: the British were offering freedom to enslaved people who escaped. Historians disagree about what Key meant. Lay out BOTH readings — the one that says he’s mocking freedom-seekers, and the one that says he means British soldiers broadly.

CLAIM — YOUR POSITION IN ONE CLEAR SENTENCE.

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EVIDENCE — AT LEAST TWO SPECIFIC THINGS FROM THIS PRESENTATION THAT SUPPORT YOUR CLAIM.

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REASONING — WHY DOES THAT EVIDENCE SUPPORT YOUR CLAIM? WHAT IS GAINED, AND WHAT IS RISKED, EITHER WAY?

REASONING — why does that evidence support your claim? What is gained, and what is risked, either way?

TEACHER ANSWER KEY — The Anthem

a. Who wrote the poem, in what year, and what was he doing on a British ship when the battle happened?: Open response.

b. Sourcing question: Key was a slaveholder watching a battle in a war where the British were freeing enslaved people. Before you read a single line, what should that make you read carefully for?: Open response.

a. The verse ends with a question mark. What exactly is Key asking — and why doesn't he know the answer yet? Point to the words that show his uncertainty.: Open response.

b. "Bombs bursting in air" sounds triumphant when we sing it. In its real moment, what did those bursting bombs actually mean for the people inside the fort?: Open response.

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CLAIM — your position in one clear sentence.: Open response.

> *Look for a response along the lines of: "Schools should / should not …"*

EVIDENCE — at least two specific things from this presentation that support your claim.: Open response.

REASONING — why does that evidence support your claim? What is gained, and what is risked, either way?: Open response.